

United States History and Government
Part A Specific Rubric (Questions 31-36)
Civic Literacy Essay
January 2025

Document 1

During World War I, President Woodrow Wilson announced his 14 Points, which he hoped would be included in the Treaty of Versailles.

“I [Woodrow Wilson] can predict with absolute certainty that within another generation there will be another world war if the nations of the world do not concert the method [agree to a plan] by which to prevent it.”

Once Wilson knew that the U.S. would be unable to avoid entering the war, he worked to find a way to stop such a war from happening again. In January 1918 he announced the 14 Points, a set of principles designed to remove the causes of another great war. The 14 Points included an international organization to keep the peace, by providing a place where disputes could be discussed and mediated. The 14 Points inspired the peoples of the Allied Nations and gave them hope that another great war could be prevented. When Wilson traveled to Europe in late 1918 to attend the Paris Peace Conference, he was met by crowds numbering in the millions in Britain, France and Italy.

At the Peace Conference in 1919, Wilson moved the seat of the presidency to Paris for six months while he commanded the attention of the world. He was faced with the leaders of the Allied Nations determined to win as many concessions and as much territory as they could for their countries. Wilson argued and fought with them through June of 1919 to make as fair a treaty as possible under the circumstances. Wilson drew up terms of peace including his design for a League of Nations, a world body to settle future conflicts among nations. . . .

Source: “League of Nations,” The President Woodrow Wilson House (adapted)

31 Based on this document, what is *one* historical circumstance surrounding the ratification of the Treaty of Versailles?

Score of 1:

- States a historical circumstance surrounding the ratification of the Treaty of Versailles based on this document

Examples: Wilson proposed including the 14 Points/League of Nations in the Treaty of Versailles; Wilson feared there would be another world war within the next generation if nations of world did not agree on plan to prevent it; unable to avoid entering World War I, Wilson worked on a plan to avoid future wars; inclusion of international organization in 14 Points gave Allied nations hope that another great war could be prevented; 14 Points included a place where disputes could be discussed/mediated; inclusion of world body to settle future conflicts among nations, including a design for a League of Nations drawn up by Wilson; during the peace conference, Wilson moved the seat of the presidency to Paris for six months; Wilson fought to make a fair treaty, despite the determination of Allied nations to win as many concessions/territories as they could

Score of 0:

- Incorrect response
Examples: United States refusing to enter World War I; 14 Points was the United States' organization to keep peace; 14 Points caused the war; Allied nations not interested in getting territory
- Vague response
Examples: predicted with absolute certainty; Wilson worked to find a way; Wilson argued and fought with them
- No response

Document 2

After discussing the proposed treaty provisions relating to the League of Nations with President Woodrow Wilson, Senator Henry Cabot Lodge gave an address to the United States Senate on February 28, 1919.

. . . Animated by the conviction that he would “follow no man and vote for no measures which, however well intended, seem in my best judgement to lead to dissensions [disagreements] rather than to harmony among the nations or to injury, peril, or injustice to my country,” and his insistence that the Senate, “which is charged with responsibility. . . should investigate every proposal with the utmost thoroughness,” Lodge’s address was a painstaking critique of the League’s constitution. He began with the impassioned argument that the document repudiated [contradicted] George Washington’s September 17, 1796, Farewell Address and the Monroe Doctrine, two sacred canons [principles] of American foreign policy. “I ask the press and the public and, of course, the Senate to consider well the gravity of this proposition,” Lodge pleaded, “before it takes the heavy responsibility of finally casting aside these policies which we have adhered to for a century and more and under which we have greatly served the cause of peace both at home and abroad.”

Turning to the specific provisions of the proposed draft, Lodge argued that the provision guaranteeing the independence and territorial integrity of all members was particularly troubling. He warned that, to insure that guarantee, the United States “must be in possession of fleets and armies capable of enforcing them at a moment’s notice.” . . .

Source: “Henry Cabot Lodge: Constitution of the League of Nations,” *Classic Senate Speeches*, U.S. Senate

32 Based on this document, what is *one* historical circumstance surrounding the debate over ratification of the Treaty of Versailles?

Score of 1:

- States a historical circumstance surrounding the debate over ratification of the Treaty of Versailles based on this document
Examples: it contradicted George Washington’s Farewell Address/Monroe Doctrine; it would cast aside policies we have followed for a century that have greatly served the cause of peace, both at home and abroad; provision guaranteeing independence and territorial integrity of all members troubling; United States would have to be in possession of fleets and armies capable of enforcing provisions at moment’s notice; insistence that Senate should investigate every proposal with thoroughness

Score of 0:

- Incorrect response
Examples: included ideas from Washington’s Farewell Address/Monroe Doctrine; the Senate was not thorough in its investigation; the United States could not have an army
- Vague response
Examples: animated by the conviction; a painstaking critique; arguments were impassioned; gravity of the proposition, this document was different
- No response

Document 3

Again and again, my fellow citizens, mothers who lost their sons in France have come to me and, taking my hand, have shed tears upon it not only, but they have added, "God bless you, Mr. President!" Why, my fellow citizens, should they pray God to bless me? I advised the Congress of the United States to create the situation that led to the death of their sons. I ordered their sons oversea. . . . They believe, and they rightly believe, that their sons saved the liberty of the world. They believe that wrapped up with the liberty of the world is the continuous protection of that liberty by the concerted [united] powers of all civilized people. They believe that this sacrifice was made in order that other sons should not be called upon for a similar gift—the gift of life, the gift of all that died. . . .

You will say, "Is the League an absolute guaranty against war?" No; I do not know any absolute guaranty against the errors of human judgment or the violence of human passion, but . . . I ask you this: If it is not an absolute insurance against war, do you want no insurance at all? Do you want nothing? Do you want not only no probability that war will not recur, but the probability that it will recur? The arrangements of justice do not stand of themselves, my fellow citizens. The arrangements of this treaty are just, but they need the support of the combined power of the great nations of the world. . . .

Source: President Woodrow Wilson, The Pueblo Speech, September 25, 1919

33 According to President Woodrow Wilson, why should the Senate approve the Treaty of Versailles?

Score of 1:

- States a reason the Senate should approve the Treaty of Versailles according to President Woodrow Wilson

Examples: so mothers would not have to lose their sons who saved the liberty of the world; the liberty of the world needs continuous protection of united powers of all civilized people; would be insurance against errors of human judgment/violence of human passion; would decrease the probability that war will recur; treaty needs the support of the combined powers of the great nations of the world; terms of treaty are just/fair

Score of 0:

- Incorrect response
Examples: League is absolute guarantee against war; Congress declared war; it is an unjust treaty; United States does not need to support the great nations of the world
- Vague response
Examples: arrangements of justice stand by themselves; insurance is not absolute; there is no probability, it's better/good
- No response

Document 4

. . . Opposition in the Senate to the Covenant of the League of Nations, led by Republican Henry Cabot Lodge of Massachusetts, was directed in particular at Article X, which stated that members would “undertake to respect and preserve as against external aggression the territorial integrity and existing political independence of all Members of the League” and that “the Council shall advise upon the means.” Many Americans believed with Lodge that through the treaty the United States would be committed to an “entangling alliance” and that other nations could determine its foreign policy by obliging it to participate in action against aggressors.

Deciding that an appeal to the country would force the Senate into line for the necessary two-thirds vote, President Wilson traveled over 8,000 miles by train and spoke forty times in twenty-two days. He became ill, and was forced to abandon his appeal. Wilson never succeeded in mustering enough votes to have the treaty passed as he had originally proposed it. Yet his belief in the original proposal was so intense that he used his influence to keep his supporters from agreeing to the changes which could have brought passage. . . .

Source: Leonard F. James, *American Foreign Policy*, Scott, Foresman and Company, 1967

34 According to Leonard F. James, what is *one* reason Senator Henry Cabot Lodge opposed the League of Nations?

Score of 1:

- States a reason Senator Henry Cabot Lodge opposed the League of Nations according to Leonard F. James
Examples: he did not like Article X; many Americans supported the belief that the United States would be committed to entangling alliances; believed other nations could determine United States’ foreign policy; United States would be obliged to participate in action against aggressors

Score of 0:

- Incorrect response
Examples: President Wilson traveled more than 8,000 miles by train; Wilson became ill and was forced to abandon his appeal; Wilson spoke 40 times in 22 days in support of the League; Wilson used influence to keep supporters from agreeing to changes; changes could have resulted in passage
- Vague response
Examples: opposition was directed; foreign policy would be determined; original proposal was intense; could have brought passage; it was bad
- No response

Document 5a

ALL MERCHANDISE
ADVERTISED IN THE
TRIBUNE IS GUARANTEED

New York Tribune

First to Last - the Truth: News-Editorials-Advertisements

Vol. LXXIX No. 26,788

SATURDAY, MARCH 20, 1920

THE WEATHER
Snow or rain to-day; probably fair and
slightly warmer to-morrow;
Increasing strong winds.
Full Report on Last Page

Senate Kills Treaty; Returns It to Wilson; Vote Is 49 to 35; 24 Democrats Oppose It

Copyright, 1920,
New York Tribune Inc.

TWO CENTS In Greater New York and
THREE CENTS Elsewhere

Source: *New York Tribune*, March 20, 1920

Document 5b

The Gap in the Bridge



Source: Leonard Raven-Hill, *Punch* (adapted)

35 Based on these documents, what is *one* impact of the efforts to ratify the Treaty of Versailles?

Score of 1:

- States an impact of the efforts to ratify the Treaty of Versailles based on these documents
Examples: Senate killed/defeated treaty; Democrats opposed treaty; vote for treaty 49 to 35 in Senate; United States did not join League of Nations; treaty returned to Wilson after Senate defeat; without United States membership, the League of Nations might not be successful; keystone of United States missing from “League of Nations Bridge”; failure of United States to join League of Nations created “Gap in the Bridge”

Score of 0:

- Incorrect response
Examples: House of Representatives passed treaty; vote was 49 to 35 in favor of treaty; Wilson passed the treaty
- Vague response
Examples: gap in the bridge; keystone USA; bridge designed by the president; it improved things
- No response

Document 6

. . . In the end Wilson failed largely because the country had never really abandoned its isolationist predilections [preferences], particularly the assumption that the United States unaided could maintain its national security. During the war, these convictions were driven underground. It is astonishing that despite the tradition of isolation, despite Wilson's collapse, despite partisan bitterness and the animosity of ethnic groups, 85 per cent of the senators voting on November 19 were willing to accept the League in some form. Yet even if the country had entered the League, it is doubtful that Americans would have been willing to assume their full obligations. The United States had not been prepared by a threat to its own security for the kind of enterprise [action] it was later to undertake in Korea. It had insufficient incentive for abandoning either isolation or absolute national sovereignty. It would take the chastening experience of World War II, Hiroshima, and the Cold War to provide that incentive. . . .

Source: William E. Leuchtenburg, *The Perils of Prosperity: 1914–1932*, The University of Chicago Press, 1993

36 According to William E. Leuchtenburg, what is *one* reason President Woodrow Wilson was not successful in gaining support for the Treaty of Versailles?

Score of 1:

- States a reason President Woodrow Wilson was not successful in gaining support for the Treaty of Versailles, according to William E. Leuchtenburg
Examples: country had never really abandoned isolationist preferences; United States felt it could maintain own national security; tradition of isolation; Wilson collapsed; partisan bitterness; animosity of ethnic groups; not enough incentive to abandon isolation/absolute national sovereignty

Score of 0:

- Incorrect response
Examples: 85 percent of voting senators willing to accept League in some form; country was ready to abandon isolation; Wilson not interested in national security; United States could not maintain its own national security
- Vague response
Examples: World War II/Hiroshima/Cold War provided experience; convictions were driven underground; he did things wrong
- No response